

Practice Paper 27 — Answer Scheme

Paper 2 — Comprehension

Sections B & C

Note to teachers and students

- Marks are awarded for **meaning**, not for exact words. Where a quotation is required, it has been indicated in inverted commas.
- Where the question asks for **own words**, a candidate who lifts directly from the text receives **zero** for that mark unless the lifted phrase is unavoidable.
- For language and tone questions, accept any reasonable alternative that clearly fits the textual evidence.

Section B — Text 3 Answer Scheme [20 marks]

Q1. [2] — “A forest of polite birds”

1 mark for identifying the **gentle, hushed, almost natural** atmosphere created by the image; **1 mark** for explaining that the **individual chirps** of the machines, taken together, form a **soft, harmonious background** — making a busy ward sound calm and almost rural.

Sample answer: The image suggests that the ward, despite being full of medical machinery, sounds **gentle and peaceful**, as though the monitors were a chorus of small, well-behaved creatures. It conveys a **hushed, almost natural calm** rather than a clinical noisiness.

Q2. [2] — Two details suggesting unusual stillness

1 mark each for any two of:

- The narrator can hear monitors “murmur” — a sound only audible in silence.
- The floor polisher had finished “hours ago” — no more activity.
- The linoleum “gleamed faintly in the low blue light” — empty, undisturbed.
- A single tap “dripped” — small sounds are noticeable.
- The hour is described as “the ward’s quietest.”

Q3. [2] — A back of separate aches

1 mark for understanding that her body is in **extreme discomfort** / fatigue; **1 mark** for the **personification** — the aches are imagined as separate voices “arguing”, which conveys how **overwhelming and disorganised** the pain has become.

Q4. [2] — The tea description

1 mark — **Physical exhaustion** / **emptiness**: the tea is cold and tasteless, suggesting she has lost interest in even small comforts.

1 mark — Emotional hollowness: the “long, hollow feeling” at four or five in the morning is the **familiar emptiness of extreme fatigue** known to anyone who has worked a full night.

Q5. [2] — Tenderness for sleeping strangers

(a) [1]: A **quiet, unobserved care** given to people the nurse does not know personally — affection without expectation of recognition or thanks.

(b) [1]: Because the tenderness is **unspoken and one-sided**; it would feel **awkward or intrusive** if the patients were awake and aware of it. (Also accept: the nurse would feel exposed or sentimental if her care were seen.)

Q6. [3] — Fear and training combined

1 mark for identifying **both** her fear **and** her professional response; **1 mark each** for **two** clearly quoted and explained details (max 2).

Accept any two of:

- “I felt my own pulse take a sudden, sharp step forwards” — physical fear, her body reacts before her mind.
- “I was already moving — pen down, fingers on his wrist, eyes on the screen” — automatic, trained response; she acts before thinking.
- “before any conscious instruction had reached my legs” — emphasises **instinctive professionalism**.
- “the years of practice... lifted me forward now as though they weighed nothing” — her training overrides her exhaustion.

Each detail must be **quoted** and **explained**; mere lifting without explanation = ½ mark.

Q7. [2] — “Indifferent” green line

1 mark — Indifferent suggests the machine **does not care** and has no awareness; it has returned to normal as though nothing had happened.

1 mark — This creates a **sharp contrast** with the narrator, who has been emotionally shaken by the brief crisis; she **feels** what the machine cannot, underlining the **human cost** of the work.

Q8. [1] — The pause before writing

1 mark: She needed a **moment to recover** from the shock / steady her hands / collect herself before resuming her professional duties. (Also accept: she was processing the fact that there had nearly been an emergency.)

Q9. [1] — Morning team not yet worn down

1 mark — Any **one** of:

- They carry “coffee in paper cups” (still fresh, still drinking it).
- Their hair is “still damp from showers.”
- Their voices are “muffled, cheerful.”
- Their faces are “innocent of everything the night had contained.”

Q10. [2] — Brisk, professional handover

1 mark — Professional **composure**: she does not wish to dramatise the moment or appear shaken in front of colleagues.

1 mark — **Self-discipline / understatement**: her training and culture of nursing value **calm, factual reporting** over emotional storytelling; the near-incident must be recorded but not inflated.

Q11. [1] — Tone of the final sentence

1 mark — Any **one** of: **reflective, humble, accepting, quietly proud, philosophical**. (Reject: **sad, bitter** — these miss the calm acceptance.)

Section C — Text 4 Answer Scheme [25 marks]

Q12. [2] — “A long, sunlit afternoon”

1 mark for understanding the suggestion of **ease, leisure, pleasure**; **1 mark** for explaining that viewers **misperceive** the work as relaxed and effortless, when in reality it is demanding.

Sample answer: The image suggests viewers believe the work is **easy, leisurely and enjoyable**, full of pleasant moments rather than effort — an idealised picture that hides the **gruelling labour** behind it.

Q13. [2] — Two income streams

1 mark each for any two of:

- **Sponsorship** — brands pay the influencer to feature a product.
- **Affiliate marketing** — commission on sales made through a personalised link.
- **Platform payouts** — a share of the platform’s advertising revenue.
- **Long tail** — merchandise, paid subscriptions and personal courses.

Q14. [1] — “Opaque” formulas

1 mark: The formulas are **not transparent** / not made public — influencers **cannot tell** how their pay is calculated or predict it reliably.

Q15. [2] — Influencer as small business owner

1 mark — The comparison **strips away** the glamorous image and reveals the influencer to be running a **solo enterprise**, with all its responsibilities.

1 mark — It emphasises the **unglamorous burdens** — long hours, lack of benefits, uncertainty of income — that the smiling video does not show.

Q16. [2] — Why income is unstable

1 mark each for any two of:

- Sponsorship contracts are **short and easily withdrawn**.
- Platforms **change their algorithms without warning**, halving an influencer’s reach overnight.
- **Income is concentrated** at the top — the top 1% earn half of all sponsorship spending.
- The median full-time creator earns **less than a starting teacher**.
- There is **no sick leave, no pension, no certainty about next month’s rent**.

Q17. [2] — Why “household name” influencers are giving way

1 mark — Smaller creators speak to **tighter, more loyal communities**, so their recommendations feel **more genuine / trustworthy**.

1 mark — **Engagement rates** of nano-influencers are far higher (roughly seven times) than those of major celebrities, **at a fraction of the cost** — so advertisers shift their spending downwards.

Q18. [1] — Effect of “quietly”

1 mark: It suggests the change has happened **unnoticed** / **without fanfare**, even though it is a major shift — the casual viewer is unaware that the industry has reorganised itself.

Q19. [2] — Regulators and advertisers

1 mark each for any two of:

- The UK’s **Advertising Standards Authority** requires **clear labelling** of sponsored posts and **names and shames** offenders.
- The US **Federal Trade Commission** has issued similar **guidance**.
- The EU’s **Digital Services Act** demands **transparency about algorithms**.
- Agencies **audit followers** for **fake** / **automated accounts** before approving a campaign.
- Brands write **performance clauses** releasing them from payment if engagement falls below a threshold.

Q20. [2] — “Rewards the very few, very visibly... obscuring the many”

1 mark — A small number of **visible successes** create the impression that success is **common and within reach**.

1 mark — The **large majority who fail** are **not visible** — there are no videos about those who quit — so the realistic odds are **hidden** from aspiring young people.

Q21. [2] — Comparison with professional acting

1 mark — Both careers are **winner-take-all** industries with **enormous rewards for a tiny minority** and **little stable income** for everyone else.

1 mark — The comparison is effective because acting is a **familiar example** of glamorous, high-risk, low-success-rate work — it gives the reader an **immediate frame of reference** for the precarity behind the glossy image.

Q22. Summary [13 marks total: 6 content + 7 style]

Content points ($\frac{1}{2}$ mark each, max 6 marks). **Eight available content points; candidates should aim for all 8.**

How influencers earn (Paragraphs 2 and 4):

1. Through **sponsorship** — brand-paid product features under short contracts.
2. Through **affiliate links** — small commissions on viewer purchases.
3. Through **platform payouts** — a share of advertising revenue from YouTube, TikTok and Instagram.
4. Through **merchandise, subscriptions and courses** — slow, “long-tail” earnings.
5. Increasingly, by reaching **smaller, more loyal audiences** as micro- or nano-influencers, who command better engagement rates.

Difficulties and risks (Paragraphs 3 and 5):

6. Income is **unstable** — contracts are short and platform algorithms change without warning.
7. **Earnings are highly unequal** — the top 1% take roughly half of sponsorship money, and most earn less than a starting teacher.

8. They face **tightening regulation and scrutiny** — required disclosure of sponsorship, follower audits, and performance clauses that can withhold payment.

Sample full-marks summary (78 words):

Online influencers earn their income through paid sponsorships, affiliate commissions, a share of advertising revenue from platforms, and slower streams such as merchandise and subscriptions; many now also serve smaller, more loyal audiences for better rates. However, their work is precarious: contracts are brief, algorithms shift overnight, and a tiny minority take most of the money while the rest earn modestly. Tightening rules on disclosure, follower audits and performance clauses add further uncertainty to the trade.

Length count: 78 words from “Online” onwards.

— END OF ANSWER SCHEME —